CHAPTER 11

GROWTH SPURT

We had all done exactly the same stuff in the off season as we always did. It was a winter away from cricket, a time to run around and play other sports. There was no working on my snap or wrist position or secret tutoring. There was nothing remarkable or different about anything I had done compared to any of the other winters. I'm expecting to come back the same player – trying hard, regularly kicking my jumper or cap away in disgust, harbouring a longing to be someone else – with Gaz and Dave, let alone everyone else, much better than me.

We are back in the nets and Dave's dad, the first team captain, is facing up. He's getting some time batting himself in against the kids, but as I run in, I suddenly sense myself to be ten times stronger than the last time I bowled. It's exhilarating, like I've been topped up in some sort of computer game, extra lives fizzing me towards the crease. I let go and the process is like lightning, the approach, the coil, the delivery, the speed the ball leaves my hand. Dave's dad, visibly stretched and taken by surprise, puts his bat down to block the ball, slightly squared up. The ball hits it and, in a moment of life-changing drama and destruction, a teenage year's worth of dreaming manifested, the Kookaburra Bubble shatters into six or seven different shards of wood. He is just standing there, looking at me with a puzzled expression on his face, still grasping the bat's handle, which is now the only part of it remaining. I am shocked too and receive his look before glancing back at my right hand that has delivered the ball. It looks the same, but as I stare quizzically into my open palm, it is as if it is twitching. I feel like Peter Parker, suddenly handed something superhuman.

I have not just gathered a yard of pace, I'm maybe 15 or 20 miles an hour quicker. I'm bowling genuinely fast. To suddenly be able to do this